compilation of the ‘baani’. Thus, Sikhism became a religion with a sacred Book. Qualities like courage, bravery, determination, initiative, sacrifice, and selfless service for the community became ingrained amongst the Sikhs. As recounted by Patwant Singh, ‘ “a will was created in the ordinary masses to resist tyranny, and to live and die for a national cause”, as two Sikh historians have it’.[5] Sikhism emerged not as a synthesis of established religions but as an alternative to them, characterized by its cultural and conceptual distinctiveness, which allowed equality between men and women and a classless society, a precept which has still not been addressed by cross-sections of Indian society.

The formidable Khalsa Empire was established by Maharaja Ranjit Singh between 1801 and 1839 in the Punjab (see Sketch 1.1). The Khalsas were quite a match even for the well-trained British Indian Army, as evidenced by the closely contested battles during the Anglo-Sikh wars, and the high attrition taken by both sides. The Sarkar Khalsaji, as the government of Ranjit Singh was called, held sway over the entire stretch of territory from the Hindu Kush and the trans-Indus areas, including Kashmir, and going right down to the Sutlej river. He established Lahore as his capital, which was the heart of the civilization of the Punjab.

Once in place, the Sikh Empire effectively blocked the route of the invaders who poured in through the Khyber and Bolan passes, and brought peace to the Punjab for a few decades. Hari Singh Nalwa, a famous general of Maharaja Ranjit Singh, carried the banner of the Khalsa Army far and wide, and had the awesome image of a ruthless warrior. However, after each Anglo-Sikh war, the Sikh Empire was clipped, till it completely fell apart because of the ineptitude of the rulers, palace intrigues and a disunited army. Not losing any opportunity to cut the Sikhs down to size and employing Machiavellian strategies, the British became masters of the whole of the Punjab by 1849. Even though they had succeeded in their strategy, the innate potential of the Sikhs as warriors was not lost sight of by the British. As a masterstroke, they got them on their side.